

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS / AI**

ment agencies—any institution that might play referee is now trusted by one side and dismissed by another.

This is the dry tinder. Generative AI is the accelerant.

The liar's dividend illustrates how this distrust plays out. In Tamil Nadu in 2023, audio clips surfaced of a DMK leader making corruption allegations. He denied the clips and claimed they were AI-generated. Independent forensic reviews later concluded one clip was likely authentic; the other was too noisy to assess conclusively and may have been manipulated. In such cases, technology provides cover for the denial, but the denial only works because the audience is already primed to trust (or distrust)—sorted into camps where inconvenient evidence gets reflexively dismissed.

GENERATION TOOLS KEEP ADVANCING, WHILE **DETECTION TECH USUALLY PLAYS CATCH-UP**. THERE IS ALSO IMPACT ASYMMETRY: ATTACKERS ONLY NEED TO SUCCEED ONCE, WHILE DEFENDERS HAVE TO CATCH EVERYTHING

This dynamic will intensify. By the time forensic analysts verify that a convincing sensational video is fake, it has already spread through encrypted messaging apps and done its work on voters—potentially in the final days before polls open. Generation tools keep advancing, while detection tech usually plays catch-up. There is also an impact asymmetry: attackers only need to succeed once, while defenders have to catch everything.

Yet it's also important to keep the threat in proportion: India's Deepfakes Analysis Unit reported that during the 2024 election period, only a small frac-